had a knee op and couldn't field for more than a couple of overs before coming off the pitch.

I'm not exactly sure why they preferred Loots to me in some of those T20 World Cup games. I know I was supposed to play in the game against Afghanistan – coach Corrie van Zyl and Graeme Smith had told me that I was taking the field – then on the morning of the game I heard Loots would play instead of me. The reason for this change was never shared with me. It was whispered by some of the press that it was because Loots had a darker skin than me, but that was ridiculous I'm sure. I am classified as a 'previously disadvantaged' player too and, though my skin tone can look a little fair at times, I thought I was pretty brown in the Caribbean. I'd been working hard on my tan.

I would love to have a go at opening again, but not under the circumstances in which I currently find myself. I feel I have to perform in order to stay in the team, when what I need to hear is, 'Hersch, you're opening the innings. Play as freely as you want and don't worry about your place. If you come off, you come off; if you don't, you won't get dropped. We know a batsman can't always score big runs, but we're confident you'll have more successes than failures.'

If I play 10 games and get the team off to six flyers but fail four times, then I think that's a good return.

The 'clique'

This issue of a clique within the Proteas team has long been a topic of discussion among the press and South African cricket fans. The team has been criticised for being run by a group of senior players – Graeme Smith, Jacques Kallis, Mark Boucher and, more recently, AB de Villiers – and this inner circle splits the team in two and makes any chance of developing true team spirit among the Proteas impossible.

Yes, these guys are very tight mates and do everything together – from hanging out during tours to going on holidays together when we aren't playing. You only have to see AB's photo on his BlackBerry Messenger – it's him, Graeme, Mark and Jacques. They always keep close tabs on what the others are doing – while Graeme was batting in one of his two 2010 IPL innings, AB sent this message around, saying, '*Die buffel bat kwaai*,' so you know they're not only out partying together, but they also watch each